Titularity & Disciplinary Identity

Abstract

This study challenges an unexamined assumption in the philosophy of science: the label “applied X” reliably indicates a substantive continuity with its parent discipline. It advances an epistemic grounding thesis, according to which disciplinary identity depends not on naming, methods, or institutional affiliation, but on the alignment of core epistemic goods and problem space. Building on recent work in the philosophy of interdisciplinarity, I reconceptualize unilateral problem feeding as a mechanism of epistemic substitution and distinguish between integrative pluralism and degenerative pluralism that erodes disciplinary coherence. Through the case of applied linguistics, I argue that titular continuity can mask a deeper transformation in epistemic orientation, resulting in disciplinary misclassification. I further justify that disciplinary institutional drift can explain how such misalignment is stabilized and reproduced. More broadly, I call for a reassessment of interdisciplinarity that foregrounds epistemic grounding as a condition for legitimate disciplinary extension.

Keywords: disciplinary identity, interdisciplinarity, epistemic grounding, epistemic pluralism, titularity

1. Introduction

In recent decades, interdisciplinarity has become a defining feature of contemporary scientific practice, reshaping not only the organization of research but also the philosophical understanding of disciplines themselves. From early programmatic visions of interdisciplinary integration (Apostel et al., 1972) to later accounts of the new production of knowledge (Gibbons et al., 1994), the trajectory of modern science has increasingly emphasized problem-orientation, collaboration, and the crossing of disciplinary boundaries. Philosophical reflection has followed suit. Rather than treating disciplines as stable, self-contained units, recent work has foregrounded their dynamic interactions, their permeability, and their dependence on broader epistemic and institutional contexts (Mäki, 2016; Schmidt, 2008).

At the same time, however, this shift has generated a fundamental tension. Interdisciplinarity is frequently associated with epistemic pluralism (Keestra & Schmidt, 2024)---the coexistence of diverse methods, perspectives, and standards of inquiry---but it is also often expected to yield some form of integration or coherence. This tension between pluralism and integration has been widely noted in the philosophical literature. Traditional accounts of interdisciplinarity, influenced by thinkers such as Erich Jantsch and Julie Klein, have tended to emphasize conceptual or theoretical integration as the defining feature of successful interdisciplinary work. More recent analysis, however, has questioned whether such integration is always attainable or even desirable. Thorén and Persson (2013, 2023) distinguish between bilateral problem feeding, in which solutions return to the source discipline, and unilateral problem feeding, in which they do not. For instance, Thorén and Persson (2013) show that climate science exports mitigation- and adaptation-related problems to social sciences, without requiring the generated policy solutions to feed back and revise climate-scientific models. By contrast, carbon-cycle-related interdisciplinary research illustrates bilateral problem feeding: ocean-chemical findings about oceanic CO_2 buffering were fed back to revise atmospheric climate modelling, maintaining reciprocal epistemic exchange between the involved disciplines.

While Thorén and Persson (2013) treat bilateral problem feeding as a legitimate non-integrative form of interdisciplinarity, I argue that unilateral problem feeding, when sustained over time, can function as a mechanism of what I call epistemic substitution, a process in which the epistemic goods of a source discipline are progressively displaced by those of a receiving discipline. The diagnosis goes beyond Thorén and Persson's account by specifying the conditions under which problem feeding becomes epistemically degenerative. This account invites further reflection on disciplinary identity, which can involve both internal coherence and social processes through which members identify with a discipline (Hyland, 2012; Osbeck & Nersessian, 2017). The present study focuses on internal coherence, which is the alignment of epistemic goods that enables problem-solving within a field. The focus is justified by my argument that epistemic substitution occurs when substituting elements displace the evaluative standards of a source discipline, such that the evaluative framework of the field loses its integrity. The question of whether a field is distinguishable from neighboring disciplines is secondary to the question of whether its own

standards of evaluation remain coherent.[1]

As Schmidt (2008) already observed, the term “interdisciplinarity” is frequently used in ways that are vague, functioning more as a rhetorical label than as a precisely defined concept. This raises the possibility that disciplinary designations, particularly those of the form “applied X”, may persist even when, within cross-field exchanges, the underlying epistemic structures they presuppose have been fundamentally altered. The specific case of “applied” disciplines has received comparatively little philosophical attention. The label “applied X” appears to imply a particular kind of relationship between an applied domain and its parent discipline, one in which theoretical insights are extended into practical contexts. However, it remains unclear under what conditions this relationship holds. Much research on interdisciplinarity has primarily focused on mechanisms of collaboration (National Academy of Sciences, 2005), patterns of knowledge exchange, or the measurement of interdisciplinarity (Wang & Schneider, 2020), yet the criteria that distinguish epistemic extension from epistemic transformation remain comparatively less explored.

I address this gap by examining the conditions under which an applied field retains or loses its epistemic grounding in its parent discipline. Unlike existing approaches that substantially study interdisciplinary collaboration, the present framework offers a diagnostic criterion: whether an applied field preserves continuity in core epistemic goods. This criterion is both more precise than general calls for pluralism and more principled than institutional classifications. It argues that in contexts of cross-disciplinary traffic, the designation “applied X” presupposes not merely a historical or institutional connection, but an ongoing alignment with the core problem space and epistemic aims of X. When such alignment is preserved, application can be understood as an extension of disciplinary knowledge. When it is not, the applied field may instead constitute a distinct epistemic domain, despite retaining its original name. In such cases, disciplinary identity becomes titular.

To develop this argument, I turn to applied linguistics as a particularly illuminating case. Applied linguistics has long defined itself in explicitly pluralistic and interdisciplinary terms, emphasizing

[1] In the following section, I show that what is problematic is the persistence of a label that no longer reflects the epistemic standards actually governing inquiry, as this undermines the comparability of knowledge claims and the transparency of evaluative practices.

its engagement with a wide range of social, educational, and psychological issues (Kaplan, 2010; *Applied Linguistics* journal, 1980-now). This orientation aligns with broader trends in problem-driven interdisciplinarity, in which research is organized around practical challenges rather than disciplinary boundaries (Papo & Potlimbrzović, 2023). However, as will be argued, this commitment to pluralism has also been accompanied by a shift in epistemic grounding. Rather than maintaining a stable relationship with linguistic theory, applied linguistics has increasingly drawn on frameworks from other disciplines, where these external frameworks come to organize research agendas.

The implications of this analysis extend beyond applied linguistics. They call into question the assumption that disciplinary identity can be sustained independently of epistemic continuity and suggest that the proliferation of interdisciplinary and applied fields may involve more profound transformations than is commonly recognized. In light of this, the present study addresses two central questions:

1. Under what epistemic conditions does an applied discipline remain grounded in its parent field, and under what conditions does it evolve into a distinct domain despite retaining its titular designation?
2. More broadly, how can the ideal of epistemic pluralism be reconciled with the need for disciplinary coherence, and when do particular forms of pluralism instead contribute to its erosion?

2. Epistemic grounding and the conditions of disciplinary identity

From early system-oriented analyses of interdisciplinarity (Apostel et al., 1972) to later developments in the theory of knowledge production (Gibbons et al., 1994), the dominant concern has been how disciplinary boundaries are crossed. Yet this focus on interaction has often come at the expense of a more fundamental question: what secures the identity of a discipline such that boundary-crossing remains intelligible as interdisciplinary rather than simply post-disciplinary? Turner (2000) has gone further, arguing that disciplines are neither reducible to styles of reasoning nor to object domains. The epistemic grounding thesis offers a third alternative: what secures

disciplinary identity is the alignment of epistemic goods, which need not coincide with either methodological style or subject matter.

Existing literature provides important but ultimately incomplete answers. Classic discussions of integration emphasize conceptual or theoretical coordination across fields (Bechtel, 1986; Darden & Maull, 1977), while subsequent critiques have stressed the fragmentation and disunity of science (Hacking, 1996; Grantham, 2004). Meanwhile, sociologically oriented accounts of knowledge production have highlighted the emergence of "mode two" research, characterized by contextualization, transdisciplinarity, and problem-orientation (Gibbons et al., 1994). However, these approaches tend to treat disciplinary identity as either stable or secondary, presupposing rather than theorizing the conditions under which a field remains meaningfully connected to its disciplinary origins.

I propose that disciplinary identity must instead be understood in terms of epistemic grounding. Whereas mode two describes institutional and problem-oriented shifts in knowledge production, the epistemic grounding thesis provides a criterion for assessing when such shifts preserve versus sever the connection of a field to its parent discipline, even where a parent discipline itself is internally plural. Drawing on insights from both philosophy of science and interdisciplinary studies, I argue that disciplines are not primarily defined by their object domains or methodological repertoires, but by their alignment with specific configurations of epistemic goods and problem spaces. While object domains may overlap and methods may be shared across fields, what distinguishes one discipline from another is the set of epistemic priorities that organizes inquiry, namely whether the aim is, for instance, the explanation of underlying structures, the construction of predictive models, or the optimization of practical interventions.

My perspective finds indirect support in several strands of the literature. For instance, research on modeling practices across disciplines has emphasized that even when identical formal-modelling resources are deployed, their epistemic roles may diverge sharply across disciplinary contexts. The same computational modelling infrastructure may serve for generating exploratory heuristic insight in archaeology, while pursuing predictive quantitative assessment in energy-usage research (Morgan & Grüne-Yanoff, 2012; Weisberg et al., 2010). Although the shared technical tool does not produce

shared disciplinary orientation, divergent epistemic priorities shape how that very same resource is put to work. Likewise, research on interdisciplinary collaboration documents a plurality of integrative strategies, many of which operate only partially across fields. Successful integration builds alignment among those underlying assumptions and evaluative standards that bear on the problem at hand, despite not having to demand consensus across an entire disciplinary framework (Hoffmann et al., 2017). The Swiss NRP 61 water management synthesis exemplifies this pattern (Swiss National Science Foundation, 2012). Hydrological, ecological, legal, and governance-focused social science contributors retained their respective discipline-wide theoretical commitments unchanged. Integration proceeded instrumentally via boundary objects such as cross-impact matrices and thematic maps, which structured heterogeneous disciplinary inputs to map resource use conflicts and assess policy-relevant management options. Integration operated at the level of practical analytical outputs.

Building on these insights, I formulate the epistemic grounding thesis, which articulates observable conditions under which an applied field maintains substantive links to its parent discipline. An applied field sustains status as an outgrowth of its parent domain when its operative evaluative benchmarks and its organizing problem space trace their provenance to the parent's established body of inquiry. This benchmark emerges from recurrent shared evaluative practice within the parent discipline, visible through patterns of argument, accepted explanatory targets, and dominant standards for judging adequate contributions. Drawing loosely on Kuhn's discussion of disciplinary matrices (Politi, 2026), the thesis foregrounds empirically traceable patterns of evaluative practice rather than adopting any one particular reading of Kuhnian disciplinary structure. When inherited evaluative benchmarks and organizing problem space remain operative within an applied domain, research activity constitutes epistemic extension. For instance, consider the importation of game-theoretic modelling into evolutionary biology: modelling resources travel into a new investigative context, while explanatory success continues to be measured against evolutionary-biological questions concerning fitness and population dynamics. This mode of cross-field deployment instantiates the kinds of conceptual coordination observed in many biological cross-domain research settings. Shifts may unfold where an applied domain gradually adopts evaluative benchmarks originating from external bodies of inquiry, reorienting its organizing problem-space around priorities exogenous to the parent discipline. Such reorientation represents

epistemic transformation. Within my investigative scope focused on "applied-X" fields, shifts can be driven by a growing orientation toward practical problem-oriented priorities that displace the parent-discipline-derived explanatory benchmarks.

My diagnosis challenges a widely held assumption in discussions of applied research, namely that the difference between "pure" and "applied" disciplines is primarily one of practical orientation. As the literature on transdisciplinarity has shown, problem-oriented research often entails a reconfiguration of both epistemic aims and evaluative criteria (Pohl, 2005; National Academy of Sciences, 2005). However, what has not been sufficiently emphasized is that such reconfiguration may fundamentally alter the epistemic identity of the field. When the central questions of inquiry are no longer derived from the theoretical concerns of the parent discipline, but from external problem contexts, the resulting field may no longer share the same epistemic grounding, even if it retains the same name.

It is useful to distinguish among three analytically separable dimensions of disciplinary organization: (i) object domain, (ii) epistemic goods, and (iii) methodological practices. While all three jointly shape disciplinary inquiry, I assign explanatory primacy to the second. A shared object domain picks out the phenomena under investigation. For example, syntactic structure may be examined by formal syntacticians, psycholinguists, and computational linguists alike. Epistemic goods set the standards that mark a contribution as successful. For formal syntax, a satisfying result may consist in a derivational account that captures distributional regularities; for computational linguistics, it may consist in reliable predictive performance. These evaluative commitments shift less readily than subject matter or tools and organize the direction a research program takes. Methodological practices comprise the investigative tools brought to bear on those phenomena, such as acceptability judgment tasks, corpus parsing algorithms, or fMRI, all of which travel easily across lines of linguistics research.

I have so far supplied the conceptual framework needed to track shifts in epistemic grounding across cross-field exchange. In what follows, I elaborate its consequences for debates over pluralism and problem-feeding, before turning to a sustained analysis of the dynamics through which applied fields may come apart from their parent disciplines.

3. From integration to problem feeding: the limits of epistemic pluralism

While early work framed interdisciplinarity in terms of theoretical coordination across domains (Darden & Maull, 1977), more recent approaches have emphasized the epistemic and practical necessity of pluralism in addressing complex, real-world problems (Coliva & Pedersen, 2017; Funtowicz & Ravetz, 1993). Yet, as has been increasingly recognized, the coexistence of multiple perspectives does not by itself guarantee epistemic productivity. The crucial issue is under what conditions it contributes to coherent knowledge production rather than to epistemic fragmentation.

The concept of problem feeding (Thorén & Persson, 2013, 2023) frames interdisciplinary exchanges as either bilateral (with reciprocal problem and solution circulation) or unilateral one-way transfers. Their three prerequisites for sustainable bilateral exchange can be illustrated with their own carbon-cycle research example from climate science. For conceptual-ontological alignment, ocean-chemistry and climate-science researchers must share a working mapping between ocean buffer system entities and atmospheric carbon cycle descriptions, so findings about oceanic CO_2 absorption can be intelligible within climate science problem formulations. Epistemological-methodological trust consists in climate scientists accepting ocean-chemical measurement and modelling outputs as valid evidence for their own inquiries. Axiological harmonization involves shared standards for judging what constitutes an adequate account of carbon-dynamics change. Substantial breakdown of these dimensions undermines the sustainability of reciprocal solution-feeding and can push disciplines toward unilateral problem transfer, a structural dependency Thorén and Persson label a Type III error, driven primarily by axiological misalignment. Under conditions of such substantial breakdown, solutions are reframed to fit epistemic commitments of a receiving field and become untranslatable against core explanatory benchmarks of a source discipline.

While full misalignment accelerates this shift, partial alignment of three prerequisites may slow long-term epistemic substitution, where the standards for valid explanation of a source field are gradually supplanted by the evaluative norms of a recipient field. Thorén and Persson's framework

offers a typology of cross-field exchange. My account advances a normative causal mechanism, reinterpreting this Type III distortion as cumulative disciplinary erosion brought on by degenerative pluralism. This diagnosis moves past the standard integration-pluralism binary to centre the direction of epistemic authority. Classic integration models presuppose two-way mutual adjustment between fields (Bechtel, 1986; Star & Griesemer, 1989). Unilateral problem-feeding can generate limited forms of reciprocal epistemic authority, such as practical data handling or local technical findings, yet these do not restore the oversight of a source field over its core explanatory and evaluative standards.

The asymmetry carries meaningful consequences. A discipline drawing on solutions from another domain may still judge those outputs against its own evaluative benchmarks. Risks emerge when external evaluative commitments are absorbed without critical examination. This shift can unfold incrementally, as imported frameworks deliver practical utility and their underlying premises gain unchallenged acceptance. Through repeated practical uptake, the evaluative benchmarks of a source field can be gradually supplanted. Practices initially adopted to resolve otherwise unmanageable research challenges can reshape the field's operative epistemic commitments. When unilateral problem-feeding takes place between fields holding divergent sets of epistemic goods, problems get reframed through the evaluative lens of a receiving field. Resulting outputs respond to the receiving field's priorities, rather than the original framing of an originating field. Exporting problems to neighboring domains can constitute a reasonable recognition of disciplinary investigative bounds. Difficulties only follow when imported solutions are incorporated without scrutiny against the source field's evaluative benchmarks.

At this point, certain boundaries within epistemic pluralism come into view. Pluralism frequently receives support because overlapping perspectives can enrich accounts of complex phenomena, on the expectation that these perspectives admit some form of coordination even when their starting assumptions diverge. Where perspectives serve mutually complementary ends, their divergence need not undermine productive inquiry; difficulties emerge when brought-together frameworks operate under incompatible epistemic priorities and gradually displace the evaluative benchmarks anchoring the original line of investigation. These observations support a narrow distinction between two trajectories available within pluralistic arrangements: disparate perspectives may

sustain a connected line of inquiry without demanding full theoretical merger, or newly introduced frameworks may erode the evaluative structure shaping the originating project. Both scenarios accommodate a plurality of viewpoints, the difference resting in the resulting trajectory of inquiry. The degenerative pattern I identify describes this second, specific outcome, triggered when pluralism operates without anchoring to a shared epistemic grounding and opens space for evaluative substitution.

The concept of degenerative pluralism allows us to reinterpret problem feeding as a specific mechanism through which epistemic degeneration occurs. In problem feeding, the asymmetrical transfer of problems creates a situation in which one discipline's epistemic goods are systematically subordinated to those of another. This process is not necessarily intentional; it may emerge from practical considerations, such as the relative availability of methods or the perceived effectiveness of certain approaches. Nevertheless, its cumulative effect is to erode the epistemic distinctiveness of the originating discipline.

Importantly, this erosion is not immediately visible at the level of institutional or nominal classification. A field may continue to bear the name of a parent discipline while orienting its work around a revised set of epistemic goods. The result is a latent disciplinary transformation, where shifts in epistemic grounding persist behind stable naming conventions. This invites inquiry into the conditions under which pluralistic arrangements sustain disciplinary coherence. Where pluralism is anchored to shared epistemic grounding, multiple perspectives may strengthen inquiry by expanding the resources available within a coherent evaluative frame. Without that anchor, pluralistic exchange can open pathways for gradual substitution of the core epistemic commitments of a field.

My observation reframes the normative weight assigned to pluralism within interdisciplinary practice. Pesch and van Uffelen (2024) defend non-domination among paradigms as a resource for contextual judgment, a claim situated within moral reasoning. I track a separate register, concerned with the structures that sustain disciplinary identity. Accounts of normative plurality can accommodate ordered or nested arrangements, and such hierarchical organization need not erase the plural value of subordinate frameworks. Epistemic plurality carries different constraints:

collaborative exchange retains its disciplinary intelligibility only if participants hold enough overlap in the standards that mark valid contribution within that domain. That minimal alignment sets boundaries for productive pluralism, separating complementarity from fragmentation. Evaluations oriented toward collaboration or perspectival diversity can overlook slower transformations in evaluative structure, allowing the language of pluralism to legitimate developments that erode the background commitments on which coherent disciplinary inquiry depends.

My argument does not advocate rigid disciplinary insularity or demand full theoretical unification across fields. I argue that intellectual humility requires acknowledging when the core inquiry of an "applied" domain no longer answers the parent discipline's theoretical questions, rather than masking epistemic reorientation under inherited titular labels. Voluntary, mutually aligned bilateral problem feeding (Thorén & Persson, 2023) remains the gold standard for non-imperialist interdisciplinary collaboration.

In this sense, the limits of epistemic pluralism arise from the tension between diversity and grounding. Recognizing such limits necessitates specifying the conditions under which pluralism remains epistemically coherent rather than degenerative. The distinction between integrative and degenerative pluralism, together with the analysis of problem feeding as a mechanism of epistemic degeneration, offers a principled way to diagnose when interdisciplinary engagement preserves an epistemic grounding of a discipline and when it facilitates its transformation. Crucially, this framework also makes it possible to move beyond abstract discussions of interdisciplinarity and to examine how such dynamics unfold within concrete fields. In particular, it raises the question of whether domains that present themselves as "applied" extensions of a parent discipline in fact operate through epistemic extension or through epistemic substitution. The following section addresses this question by turning to a specific case, showing how the mechanisms identified here can lead to a divergence between titular designation and epistemic identity.

4. Titularity without identity: the case of applied linguistics

I refer to applied linguistics to demonstrate the central claim developed in the previous section,

namely, that disciplinary identity depends on the continuity of epistemic goods and core problem space. The case of applied linguistics illustrates how a field may shift from epistemic extension to epistemic substitution. This shift reflects a reconfiguration of epistemic goods and problem space. Where earlier configurations were at least partially oriented toward applying linguistic theory to practical domains (e.g. Lamendella, 1969), many current configurations are organized around problem domains whose epistemic orientation is no longer anchored in linguistics as a theoretical enterprise (Weideman, 2016). The result is a transformation in the conditions that would justify the label "applied linguistics" in the first place. What makes it a concern is that the persistence of the inherited label obscures the epistemic basis of research and the transparency of evaluative standards within the field.

Weideman (2016) offers a different account of the distinctiveness of applied linguistics, proposing a distinction between the "lingual" modality (concerned with language as an object of inquiry) and the "technical" modality (oriented toward the design of interventions in problem domains). While this framework provides a principled basis for differentiating the two domains, it remains primarily conceptual. What it leaves less clear is how shifts in problem space and epistemic goods unfold over time, and how such shifts may lead to a gradual decoupling from the parent discipline. It is precisely this dynamic process that the present account seeks to capture in terms of epistemic substitution.

On the epistemic grounding thesis, disciplinary identity rests on continuity of epistemic goods and core problem space. Linguistic inquiry, across formal and cognitive-functional frameworks, prioritizes explanations of language as a structured system, centred on competence, structural patterning and situated usage. A substantial body of contemporary applied linguistics is organized around distinct evaluative commitments: pedagogical effectiveness, social equity, identity construction and policy intervention (Block, 2003; Pennycook, 2022). Much of the dominant trajectories in the field proceed without linguistic constructs, framing questions and validating conclusions through standards independent of linguistic analysis.

This arrangement can't be reduced to ordinary interdisciplinary expansion. Interdisciplinarity recognizes a spectrum from integration to loose juxtaposition (Klein, 1990; Barry et al., 2008).

What distinguishes this case is its pattern of theoretical dependence. Linguistics is no longer mandatory grounding, while external frameworks supply puzzles and evaluative benchmarks needed to pursue the commitments noted above. Language learning research may deploy constructs from educational psychology (e.g. Cheng et al., 2025); scholarship centred on pedagogical design targets sustained improvements in educational outcomes (Huang & Chalmers, 2023); discourse identity scholarship draws on sociological and post-structuralist premises (e.g. Block, 2007; Norton, 2014); critical applied linguistics treats social justice as a core organizing construct for transformative language education inquiry (e.g. Keleş, 2026); language policy research investigates the interplay between human agency and institutional structure within processes of multilingual policy formation and implementation (e.g. McEntee-Atalianis & Hult, 2025). These analyses are self-contained within those external frameworks and require no anchoring to the linguistic system. Knowledge flow runs unidirectionally: imported analytical tools are not reintegrated into linguistically grounded explanation. This issue constitutes epistemic substitution, a form of degenerative pluralism. The link between applied linguistics and linguistics becomes nominal rather than epistemic.

My diagnosis challenges the prevailing self-conception in applied linguistics, which frames its strength as openness to diverse perspectives and responsiveness to real-world concerns (Kaplan, 2010; *Applied Linguistics* journal, 1980-now). Practical social orientation carries no inherent defect. The critical difficulty arises when such orientation decouples from any requirement to mobilize linguistic resources. Openness unmoored from stable epistemic commitments preserves no inherent continuity with the parent discipline; its proliferating analytical vocabularies mark a field capable of operating apart from the linguistic frameworks that originally motivated its name. Studies of interdisciplinary collaboration have shown that successful integration requires diversity and mechanisms for coordinating and evaluating contributions (Huutoniemi et al., 2010; Rafols & Meyer, 2010). In the absence of such mechanisms, interdisciplinarity may result in what has been described as “fragmented adhocracy”, characterized by loosely connected research practices without a shared epistemic core. Applied linguistics, in its current configuration, exhibits many of these features: a wide range of topics, methods, and theoretical orientations (Phakiti et al., 2018), but limited agreement on what constitutes a central cumulative body of knowledge in relation to linguistics.

This contrast draws out how (integrative and degenerative) pluralism operates differently across paired theoretical and applied fields. Pure mathematics contains separate subfields such as analysis and geometry, each with its own questions and toolkits. Applied mathematicians modelling groundwater flow may combine analytical existence proofs for partial differential equations with geometric discretisation schemes and numerical approximation routines borrowed from computational mathematics. These disparate pieces do not operate independently. If a chosen discretisation scheme produces outputs that violate the proven bounds on solution behavior established in analysis, that numerical work can't stand as a valid mathematical contribution, no matter how well it tracks observed field data. Every imported technique must respect the constraints laid down by prior mathematical results, so the diversity of methods continually feeds back into and extends a shared cumulative record. Applied linguistics, by contrast, hosts heterogeneous research streams whose internal standards operate free from such binding cross-constraint.

A critic might object that the foregoing portrait of applied linguistics neglects subfields retaining tight ties to linguistic theory, such as second language acquisition research informed by generative linguistics (e.g. Slabakova et al., 2020) or usage-based models (e.g. Cadierno & Eskildsen, 2015). This objection is accepted but does not undermine the present claim. Indeed, not every contribution to applied linguistics has severed its epistemic grounding, but the disciplinary center of gravity, measured by publication output, citation impact, and self-definition in leading journals, has shifted toward non-linguistic epistemic goods (Meihami & Esfandiari, 2024). What matters for the charge of titularity without identity is that the dominant, field-defining trajectory no longer requires linguistic grounding, such that a researcher can be a recognized contributor to general humanities. The persistence of linguistically grounded subfields only confirms that the field is epistemically stratified, not that the stratification is harmless to disciplinary coherence.

A more substantial objection is that the reorientation of applied linguistics toward social and educational concerns reflects a legitimate expansion of its scope, rather than a loss of identity. From this perspective, the field has simply evolved to address more complex and socially relevant problems, and its interdisciplinarity is a necessary response to those challenges (Schmitz, 2010). Those advancing this view need not explicitly assume identity can persist apart from shared

epistemic goods. They instead treat continuity of institutional label and thematic breadth as sufficient to carry disciplinary continuity, which is a tacit commitment to be contested. Scope may expand while identity remains stable only if the underlying epistemic goods stay aligned with those of the parent discipline. Where alignment lapses, the outcome is not extension into new terrain but fundamental transformation.

At this point, the notion of titularity without identity can be specified more precisely. A field exhibits titularity without identity when its name suggests a relation to a parent discipline that is not borne out by its epistemic structure. In applied linguistics, the titular reference to linguistics implies a grounding in the study of natural languages as such. Disciplinary labels supply default orienting cues for policy makers, funding bodies, outside researchers, students, and the public, who rely on such markers to anticipate the characteristic modes of inquiry in a field and evaluative standards. Where a label diverges from the epistemic commitments organizing actual research, the shared vocabulary for evaluation and cross-field collaboration carries inherent structural risk.

My analysis does not entail that applied linguistics is illegitimate as a field of inquiry. On the contrary, the problems it addresses, like language education, multilingualism, and critical discourse, are of undeniable importance. Their shared focus on linguistic material can create the impression of unified subject matter, even when the guiding evaluative standards are drawn from education, sociology, or cultural studies. Retaining the label “applied linguistics” under such conditions risks conflating distinct epistemic projects and obscuring their respective standards of validity. In this sense, applied linguistics provides a paradigmatic example of how epistemic substitution can lead to a divergence between titular designation and disciplinary identity. It illustrates how the mechanisms identified in previous sections, especially problem feeding and degenerative pluralism, can operate at the level of an entire field, producing a condition in which epistemic grounding is progressively displaced while nominal continuity is preserved. Later, I examine how institutional structures contribute to the stabilization and reproduction of such conditions, turning what might otherwise be a transient phase into a durable feature of the academic landscape.

5. Institutional drift and the reproduction of disciplinary misclassification

I have shown that unregulated epistemic pluralism and unilateral problem feeding enable applied fields to shift from epistemic extension to epistemic substitution. Yet this framework remains incomplete without an account of why dislocated fields retain inherited "applied X" labels rather than undergoing formal disciplinary reclassification. This section introduces the concept of disciplinary institutional drift to explain the structural forces stabilizing mismatches between nominal disciplinary identity and underlying epistemic commitments, drawing path-dependence analogies from institutional policy scholarship (Wiley & Reed, 2024).

Disciplinary institutional drift describes a decoupling process. The evaluative, funding and organisational infrastructures of a field persist with their traditional naming conventions, even as core epistemic goods diverge from the parent discipline. Sustained by academic incentive structures, authority hierarchies and accumulated symbolic capital (Glasford & Brown, 2025), this mismatch between titularity and epistemic identity becomes a durable, structurally embedded state rather than a temporary transitional quirk.

Science studies scholarship frames disciplines as dual constructs: they function both as coherent epistemic systems and institutionalised knowledge apparatuses sustained by departments, journals, professional bodies and funding pipelines (Whitley, 2024). These institutional arrangements exhibit strong path dependence, reproducing long-standing disciplinary taxonomies independently of evolving research practices (Weideman, 2016). Epistemic evolution therefore rarely triggers parallel institutional restructuring, creating persistent gaps between official field categorisation and actual evaluative standards.

Such institutional decoupling does not unfold uniformly across all applied domains. Fields with robust shared repertoires for theoretical translation, such as applied mathematics and applied physics, sustain tight continuity with their parent disciplines. Their research outputs must remain expressible within the parent field's established theoretical vocabulary (Pérez-Escobar & Sarikaya, 2022). This arrangement sustains feedback that preserves the parent's explanatory authority and limits wholesale epistemic substitution. Some other domains lack comparable shared repertoire.

Lines of research whose evaluative benchmarks are anchored primarily to practical outcomes may operate without stable mechanisms to fold those outcomes back into the parent discipline's evaluative standards. That absence makes epistemic substitution easier to entrench institutionally, even where the field was never built around a single axiomatic core.

Applied linguistics embodies this structural asymmetry. While its institutional architecture (e.g. university programmes, flagship journals, dedicated funding streams) retains the label "linguistics", its dominant research priorities have shifted toward external social and educational problem domains, generating a permanent split between titular continuity and epistemic discontinuity. Three mutually reinforcing institutional mechanisms lock this misclassification in place. First, research assessment frameworks define excellence along field-specific rather than parent-discipline epistemic lines (Lamont, 2009). Within applied linguistics, evaluative benchmarks prioritize educational impact, social equity and methodological pluralism over alignment with linguistic explanatory frameworks (Li et al., 2025), incentivizing scholars to orient inquiry toward external epistemic goods and accelerating substitution. Second, contemporary funding regimes prioritize problem-centred, socially impactful interdisciplinary work (Nowotny et al., 2021). Research addressing educational or societal intervention receives disproportionate resource support relative to work centred on linguistic theoretical explanation, further skewing the field's epistemic centre of gravity. Third, journal editorial policies institutionalize broad, socially oriented scope remits (*Applied Linguistics* journal, 1980-now; *Language & Education* journal, 1987-now; *System* journal, 1973-now), elevating non-linguistic problem frames in publication and citation cycles and gradually redefining the field's core epistemic territory.

Three interconnected institutional processes, namely reoriented evaluation criteria, impact- centred funding priorities, and socially focused journal gatekeeping, operate as a self-reinforcing feedback loop that normalizes epistemic substitution under unchanged disciplinary branding. This structural reproduction rarely faces critical pushback, as prominent disciplinary discourse frames broad ontological - epistemological diversity as a core disciplinary strength (Dewaele, 2019). Such normative framing can obscure gradual erosion of the epistemic grounding of a parent discipline. A striking paradox emerges: applied linguistics has expanded its institutional footprint via new degrees, journals and professional organizations even as its reliance on linguistic core epistemic

goods weakens, demonstrating that institutional growth bears no necessary relation to epistemic coherence.

My institutional analysis carries wider philosophical implications for theories of disciplinary identity. Existing scholarship recognizes that disciplinary structures emerge from historically contingent institutional dynamics. Even so, the drift framework highlights a persistent, under-examined disconnection, namely between the core epistemic commitments of a field and its inherited institutional labeling of it. The three institutional mechanisms outlined above may operationalize this divide, showing how nominal disciplinary categories can endure through substantial shifts in what counts as valid explanation within a field.

Epistemic substitution triggered by institutional drift generates both descriptive real-world costs and normative philosophical defects, a dual misclassification harm insufficiently foregrounded in prior interdisciplinary work. Descriptively, mislabeling confuses evaluators, graduate training designers and funding bodies, who can't reliably map the titular name of a field to its operative standards of evidence and explanation. Normatively, it invalidates the foundational presupposition of "applied X" as legitimate epistemic extension, which hinges on sustained alignment with the parent field's core problem space and explanatory aims. Thorén & Persson's (2023) three-dimensional preconditions for bilateral problem feeding clarify why this dual harm arises. Permanent substitution severs the conceptual and axiological alignment required for reciprocal cross-disciplinary dialogue, trapping the field in one-sided epistemic subordination that undermines coherent knowledge exchange, graduate curriculum design, and equitable resource allocation across academia.

My observation questions whether institutional drift should be resisted or accepted as a natural stage of knowledge evolution. The answer hinges on whether disciplinary epistemic coherence counts as an essential condition for rigorous, comparable problem-solving. If disciplines exist to sustain structured frameworks for targeted theoretical or practical inquiry, the loss of shared core epistemic goods constitutes a substantive intellectual cost, even when offset by greater social relevance or institutional expansion. A purely instrumental reading of scholarship might dismiss this coherence loss as negligible, yet misclassification carries tangible practical risks beyond abstract conceptual confusion. When work framed as "applied linguistics" mixes research governed by linguistic

explanatory standards with inquiry oriented toward educational or sociological aims, uniform assessment of scholarly contributions becomes impossible, distorting training pathways, funding distribution, and public understanding of distinct research domains. Crucially, disciplinary transformation is not inherently degenerative: shifts qualify as legitimate epistemic extension so long as they retain alignment with the parent's core epistemic goods and satisfy Thorén & Persson's (2023) prerequisites for bilateral problem feeding. Only sustained unilateral problem feeding and full substitution produce the degenerative drift outlined in this chapter, avoiding the false binary that all interdisciplinary evolution erodes disciplinary identity.

In sum, titularity without identity can't be fully analyzed without accounting for institutional drift as a stabilizing structural force. The three interconnected institutional mechanisms detailed above turn temporary epistemic divergence into a permanent feature of academic organization. By integrating institutional sociology with the epistemic grounding thesis, this analysis extends philosophy of interdisciplinarity into science policy and research governance, arguing that rigorous disciplinary evaluation and classification must account for both epistemic core commitments and the institutional structures that distort nominal field labels over time.

6. Conclusion

I have argued that disciplinary identity can't be secured by titular continuity alone, but depends on what has been termed an epistemic grounding condition: the alignment of the core problem space and epistemic goods with those of its parent discipline. By distinguishing between epistemic extension and epistemic substitution, and by reconceptualizing unilateral problem feeding as a mechanism of epistemic degeneration, I show how applied fields may undergo substantive transformation while retaining their inherited names. The case of applied linguistics demonstrates that such a transformation is stabilized through processes of disciplinary institutional drift. On broader implications, the contemporary celebration of interdisciplinarity and pluralism, when detached from conditions of epistemic grounding, risks legitimizing forms of disciplinary misclassification. If disciplinary identity is to retain analytical and normative significance, it must be evaluated not by institutional labels or rhetorical commitments to diversity, but by the underlying

epistemic structures that define what counts as knowledge within a field.

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